
Chronic Pain — The Long Game

Companion Workbook — build your multi-modal
management plan

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #10 Workbook

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Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC10 DEEP cut. Build your multi-modal management plan.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

YEAR-LONG REFERENCE. SELF-ASSESSMENT first. Build your team. Establish daily practice. Track over time. Flare plan ready when needed.

Bring to all healthcare appointments — having this written record helps every provider you work with.

CHAPTER 2

Chronic Pain Self-Assessment

Pain characteristics

DURATION: _____ MONTHS/YEARS

Constant vs intermittent: _____

Intensity range (0-10): Best ____ / Worst ____ /
Average ____

Primary location(s): _____

Specific original injury or trigger (if any):

What helps and hurts

Things that reduce my pain:

Things that increase my pain:

Impact assessment

Sleep impacted: ☐ No / ☐ Some / ☐ Significant / ☐ Severe

Work impacted: ☐ No / ☐ Some / ☐ Significant / ☐ Severe

Relationships impacted: ☐ No / ☐ Some / ☐ Significant / ☐ Severe

Activities I've stopped due to pain:

Mood, stress, sleep

- Mood (1-10): [____]
- Stress (1-10): [____]
- Anxiety about pain (1-10): [____]
- Sleep quality (1-10): [____]

Treatment history

Mark all you've tried:

- ☐ Primary care physician
- ☐ Specialist (which): _____
- ☐ Physical therapy
- ☐ Bodywork / massage
- ☐ Chiropractic
- ☐ Acupuncture
- ☐ Pain medication (which): _____
- ☐ Pain specialist
- ☐ Pain psychologist
- ☐ Surgery
- ☐ Injection therapies
- ☐ Mental health therapy
- ☐ Mindfulness / meditation
- ☐ Diet changes
- ☐ Other: _____

Pattern identification

Which pattern from IC10 most resembles my situation?

- ☐ Been to every specialist, nothing works
- ☐ Imaging-focused (have findings, assume they explain pain)
- ☐ Push-through pattern (boom-bust cycle)

- [] Withdrawal pattern (stopped doing things)
 - [] Trauma-related
 - [] Already in manageable phase
 - [] Combination of above
-

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: HOW HAS CHRONIC PAIN SHAPED your sense of who you are? What things have you stopped doing because of pain? What things define you that pain hasn't taken?

Prompt 2: What's the story you tell yourself about your pain? "It's because of my [injury/disease/age/job]." Is that story complete? What else might be contributing?

Prompt 3: What would “managed well” look like for you? Not cured — managed. What would your life look like if pain was a smaller part of your daily experience?

CHAPTER 4

My Care Team

BUILD THIS OUT OVER TIME. MOST CHRONIC PAIN benefits from 3-5 of these.

Primary care physician:

Name: _____
Last visit: _____ / Next visit: _____

Pain specialist (if applicable):

Name: _____
Last visit: _____ / Next visit: _____

Physical therapist:

Name: _____
Last visit: _____ / Next visit: _____

Bodyworker (Nate or other):

Frequency of sessions: _____
Last session: _____ / Next session: _____

Mental health professional:

Name: _____
Last visit: _____ / Next visit: _____

Other providers:

Gaps in team I need to fill:

CHAPTER 5

My Daily Pain Management Practice

SLEEP PRACTICES (FROM IC8/MODULE 3):

- [] Bedtime: ____
- [] Wake time: ____
- [] Cool room
- [] Consistent schedule
- [] Screen cut-off: ____

Movement (from IC9, modules):

- [] Daily mobility: ____ minutes at ____
- [] Walking: ____ minutes per day

Stress/nervous system (from Modules 1, 2, 4, IC4):

- [] Daily breathing: ____ minutes at ____
- [] Body scan: ____ times per day
- [] Vagal technique: ____

Other practices that help me:

CHAPTER 6

My Flare Response Plan

WHEN PAIN SPIKES, HERE'S MY PLAN:

Immediate actions:

1.

2.

3.

Activities I'll scale back:

Practices I'll increase:

Who I'll contact if it persists or worsens:

When to seek emergency care:

- [] New severe pain
- [] Neurological symptoms (numbness, weakness, tingling)
- [] Bowel/bladder issues
- [] Pain with fever
- [] Thoughts of self-harm — **988 immediately**

CHAPTER 7

90-Day Pain Tracker

TRACK ONCE A WEEK FOR 90 DAYS. IDENTIFIES patterns over time.

Week 1

DAY	DATE	PAIN (0-10)	SLEEP (1-10)	STRESS (1-10)	NOTES
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					

Week 2-12

Continue pattern. Use any notebook or app, or photocopy this page.

After 90 days — pattern analysis

Average pain: _ (compared to Day 1: __)

Days with pain above 7: ____ out of 90

Days with pain below 4: ____ out of 90

Correlations I notice:

- Sleep quality and pain: _____
- Stress and pain: _____
- Activities that consistently help: _____
- Activities that consistently flare: _____

Biggest insight from 90 days of data:

CHAPTER 8

Quarterly Check-Ins

Q1 Check-In — Date: ____

AVERAGE PAIN PAST 90 DAYS: _____

Compared to 90 days ago: ☐ Better / ☐ Same /
☐ Worse

Team adjustments needed:

Practice adjustments:

Q2-Q4 Check-Ins

Continue same pattern quarterly.

CHAPTER 9

Year-End Reflection

COMPARED TO ONE YEAR AGO:

- Pain intensity: [] Better / [] Same / [] Worse
- Pain interference with life: [] Less / [] Same / [] More
- Mood and outlook: [] Better / [] Same / [] Worse
- Sense of management/control: [] More / [] Same / [] Less

Biggest shift this year:

What worked most:

What I'll commit to for next year:

CHAPTER 10

Try this for 30 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Three basics. Every day. For 30 days.

1. Sleep 8 hours with consistent schedule
2. 10 minutes of gentle daily movement
3. 5 minutes of slow exhale breathing before bed

Don't add anything else. Don't change anything else.

The three basics done consistently for 30 days often reduce chronic pain intensity by a meaningful amount in many people. Not always. Often.

If it helps — build from there. If it doesn't — make sure your team is right.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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